

Dynamic Populations

More than half the people of the world currently live in urban areas. With global urban population numbers rising by 180,000 each day, it is predicted that by 2050 two-thirds of the world's population will be city dwellers.

Urbanization became a worldwide phenomenon in the 20th century as the populations of less economically developed nations in South America, Asia, and Africa followed the Western trend for urban migration.

Urbanization is not constrained by national boundaries. Many migrants move countries in search of a better life, generally moving from developing countries to the developed world.

Growing concerns

People continue to be drawn to cities by the promise of economic and social opportunity. Cities are political, cultural, and commercial centers where much of a nation's essential work is done. However, expanding urban population numbers place heavy demands on the infrastructures of modern cities where poverty often exists side by side with great affluence. Lack of housing has contributed to increasing numbers of people living on the streets and there is serious concern about the spread of infectious diseases, including tuberculosis and HIV/Aids (see pp.464–65) among the poor and homeless.

Crime is another problem in most of the world's major cities. There is particular concern about violent crime among urban youth. Issues of poverty and social exclusion are thought to have contributed to growing youth violence and the use of firearms has led to the creation of "zones of lawlessness" in certain cities.

Third World cities are currently expanding at the fastest rate. Here, many migrants flee war or rural poverty to find themselves living in slums without hope of work, adequate shelter, sanitation, or clean water supplies. In sub-Saharan Africa, 70 percent of the urban population are slum-dwellers.

KEY

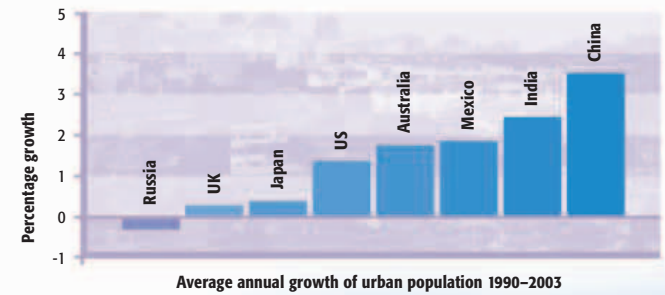
- City population in 1950 (millions)
- City population in 1975 (millions)
- City population in 2000 (millions)

Shifting city populations

The recorded rises in urban population numbers since 1950 reflect differing rates of industrialization across the globe. Urban explosion in Latin America, India, Asia, and China can be seen in the leap in population numbers since 1975.

Urban growth

Comparative urban population numbers since 1990 show that European and Japanese urban population growth has slowed. Urbanization continues to increase in the US, Australia, and Mexico, and rates in India and China are rising at a dramatic rate.



BEFORE

During the Industrial Revolution there was a rapid mass migration of people from rural to urban areas across Europe and the US.

URBANIZATION

In 1800, one in four British people lived in cities, but by 1900 it was three in four. This process of migration, known as urbanization, occurred across Europe and North America during the Industrial Revolution << 292–95. The sudden concentration of large numbers of people in cities and towns << 322–25 created crowded and unsanitary conditions. The Western world gradually addressed these social problems, developing infrastructures that could provide the necessary support for their industrial workforces. Because opportunity for advancement was located in the city, urban populations continued to grow.



ARRIVING IN NEW YORK



San Francisco's Chinatown was a ghetto established by Chinese immigrants in the city's downtown area in the 1850s. It was once an impoverished area shunned by non-Chinese, but today it is a vibrant, thriving tourist destination.



Mexico City, the capital of Mexico, has over 8 million inhabitants, the poorest of whom live in shanty towns or favelas. Favela shacks are built with whatever materials come to hand and are notoriously unsafe and vulnerable to landslides.



Brazilian troops were among the masses of military personnel that were deployed around the world during World War II. This movement led to many more marriages between peoples of different nationalities. Postwar, many brides returned to live in their husbands' home countries.

